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April 27, 2026

**U.S. Election Assistance Commission
633 3rd Street NW, Suite 200
Washington, DC 20001
Docket ID EAC-2026-0067**

Re: Public Comment Regarding Election Audit Standards

To the Commissioners of the United States Election Assistance Commission:

Honest Elections Project is a nonpartisan, nonprofit entity fighting for the right of every American to vote in free and honest elections. When voters can see that elections are run properly, it promotes confidence in the legitimacy of the results. Election audits are vital for building trust in elections and delivering on what voters want: more transparency. In fact, HEP Action polling showed 95% of registered voters agree that every election should be transparent and accountable to the voters, and [86%](#) of the public agrees that election offices should be routinely reviewed and audited.

As the standards recognize, “[e]lection administration is a complex and highly specialized field characterized by a high degree of decentralization.” Election processes vary greatly state to state and county to county within each state. Whether a jurisdiction uses tabulation equipment or electronic poll books, equipment type, poll worker recruitment and training, and absentee ballot processing are just a few of the many variables directly impacting election administration.

With increased attention on elections and election administration, audits offer evidence-based assurance that election outcomes can be trusted. When things do go wrong in an election, audits help election officials identify and address problems and provide information for states to use in determining important policy questions. While [most](#) states have some form of election audits in place, what gets reviewed and the scope of the review differs greatly depending upon the type of audit used. Traditional audits verify tabulators properly counted the votes on a ballot, while procedural audits involve more comprehensive and robust reviews of compliance with election laws and processes. As states recognize and act to meet the increased need for transparency, these basic principles for election audits provide a framework that will promote consistency in approach, even where the type of audit or election processes differ.

Striking the right balance between flexibility – to accommodate variations in election administration – and consistency in core audit principles is a challenge. This challenge is further compounded by the fact that so many types of election audits exist. There are some fundamentals that need to be considered when prescribing standards in the election space. Audited parties need to know what to expect in an audit so they can be prepared, auditors need the flexibility to follow the data where it leads, and the public needs to be able to understand and see the evidence upon



which they can base their trust in the results. The EAC's audit standard topics are objectivity, professionalism, effectiveness, security, and accountability. These topics encompass principles that should be the hallmarks of any election audit.

The proposed standards provide a balanced, yet cautious framework that allows auditors to tailor their operations to the distinctive needs of a particular state. They also promote public confidence in the audit process by giving examples of how auditors can demonstrate commitment to these principles (*"For the standard of competence, we conduct audits that include an experienced election official to ensure compliance with technical and legal requirements."*). The standards help auditors preserve independence and avoid the risk or appearance of bias or external influence, offer guidance in structuring and planning audits, and promote open communication with the public throughout the process.

Recognizing the unique nature of election administration and [variety](#) of election audits, the standards appropriately refrain from prescribing a particular manner in which to incorporate the standards yet offer concrete examples and explanations of the underlying principles. For example, when discussing the qualifications of auditors, instead of requiring certain qualifications or certifications, the standards correctly focus on the audit team's collective knowledge, skills, and experience to conduct an audit effectively.

These standards offer a much-needed framework that states can adjust to their needs to help ensure the same goal is reached no matter the type of audit conducted: promoting consistency and trust in the reliability of an audit's results. There are a couple of suggestions that the EAC may want to consider in finalizing these standards:

- On page 24, under the standard of Efficacy, the standards state "No one audit can check every part of the election." While this is true, a qualifier might assist in giving a better understanding of this concept. For example, "While no one audit can check every part of the election, some audits do involve a fulsome review of election processes from start to finish or a combination of different types of audits can give voters confidence in each of the audited components of the election."
- On pages 31-32, the standards discuss Public Communication. While public communication is necessary and often underutilized, there is a corresponding need for communication with the audited party. In conducting an audit, auditors will undoubtedly encounter scenarios where the data appears to tell a certain story or lend itself to a certain conclusion. Without context, however, the story or conclusion could be entirely incorrect. An important component of a good audit is ensuring thorough and open communication between the auditor and the audited party. This ensures audit results are accurate and bolsters the credibility of the audit team.

Regardless of the outcome of any contest, voters must be able to have confidence in the election process. A government's legitimacy depends on the consent of the governed, including those whose candidate did not win. These standards are an important part of bringing more transparency and accountability to elections, thus increasing voter confidence in the results.